

Active Listening Self-Assessment

15 questions across 4 listening dimensions, with a scoring guide and development tips for each area.

How to Complete This Assessment

- Rate yourself honestly on each statement from 1 (Never) to 5 (Always), based on your actual behavior, not your intentions
- Answer based on a specific recent relationship or context (e.g. "conversations with my direct reports") if your listening varies a lot across situations — don't average across every relationship in your life
- There are no right answers to fake — this is useful only if it's honest

The Four Listening Dimensions

Dimension	What It Covers
Attending	Giving full, visible attention — minimizing distraction and signaling engagement
Understanding	Actively checking comprehension rather than assuming you've understood correctly
Withholding Judgment	Staying genuinely open while someone speaks, rather than forming a rebuttal or verdict mid-sentence
Responding	What you do after listening — asking real follow-up questions rather than jumping straight to advice

The Assessment

Rate each statement: 1 (Never) – 2 (Rarely) – 3 (Sometimes) – 4 (Often) – 5 (Always)

Attending (Questions 1-4)

1. I put away my phone or close other windows/tabs when someone is speaking to me directly. ____
2. I maintain appropriate eye contact and open body language while listening. ____
3. I notice when my attention has drifted and consciously bring it back to the speaker. ____
4. I give people my full attention even when I'm confident I already know what they're going to say. ____

Understanding (Questions 5-8)

5. I paraphrase back what I heard before responding, to confirm I understood correctly. ____
6. I ask clarifying questions when something is ambiguous, rather than guessing at the meaning. ____
7. I notice the difference between what someone is saying and what they actually mean. ____
8. I check my understanding of emotionally significant points, not just factual details. ____

Withholding Judgment (Questions 9-12)

9. I let people finish their point without interrupting, even when I strongly disagree. ____
10. I notice when I've started mentally preparing my response before the other person has finished speaking. ____
11. I can accurately summarize a position I disagree with before I respond to it. ____
12. I stay curious about why someone holds a view, rather than immediately categorizing it as wrong. ____

Responding (Questions 13-15)

13. I ask a genuine follow-up question before offering advice or a solution. ____
14. I check whether someone actually wants advice before giving it. ____
15. I reflect back the emotional content of what someone shared, not just the facts. ____

Scoring Interpretation

Add your scores for each dimension's questions, then find the corresponding band below. Do this per dimension — a single overall number hides which specific area needs attention.

Dimension	Questions	Max Score	Developing (below 60%)	Solid (60-80%)	Strength (above 80%)
Attending	1-4	20	Below 12	12-15	16-20
Understanding	5-8	20	Below 12	12-15	16-20
Withholding Judgment	9-12	20	Below 12	12-15	16-20
Responding	13-15	15	Below 9	9-11	12-15

A “Developing” score in one dimension while others are strong is common and useful information — it tells you specifically where to focus, rather than treating listening as one undifferentiated skill.

Development Tips Per Area

If Attending scored Developing

- Physically remove your phone from the table during important conversations, not just silence it
- Before a conversation you know will be difficult to focus on, name to yourself why full attention matters here specifically
- Notice your own tell for drifting attention (checking the time, glancing at a screen) and treat it as a cue to re-engage

If Understanding scored Developing

- Practice a simple paraphrase habit: “So what I'm hearing is...” before responding, even briefly
- When something is ambiguous, ask rather than assume — a wrong assumption compounds through the rest of the conversation
- Pay particular attention to checking understanding on emotionally loaded points, where misreading costs the most

If Withholding Judgment scored Developing

- Notice the specific moment you start composing a response instead of listening, and consciously return to listening
- Practice being able to restate a position you disagree with, accurately, before responding to it — this alone catches most premature judgment
- Build in a brief pause after someone finishes speaking before you respond, even half a second, to break the reflex to jump in

If Responding scored Developing

- Before offering advice, ask directly: “Are you looking for suggestions, or do you just want to think out loud?”

- Practice one genuine follow-up question before moving to solutions, even when you're confident you already know the answer
- Reflect back feeling, not just fact: "That sounds like it was really frustrating" lands differently than jumping straight to a fix

Revisit this assessment in 2-3 months after deliberately practicing one or two of the tips above — listening habits shift gradually, not from a single reading of a development tip.